

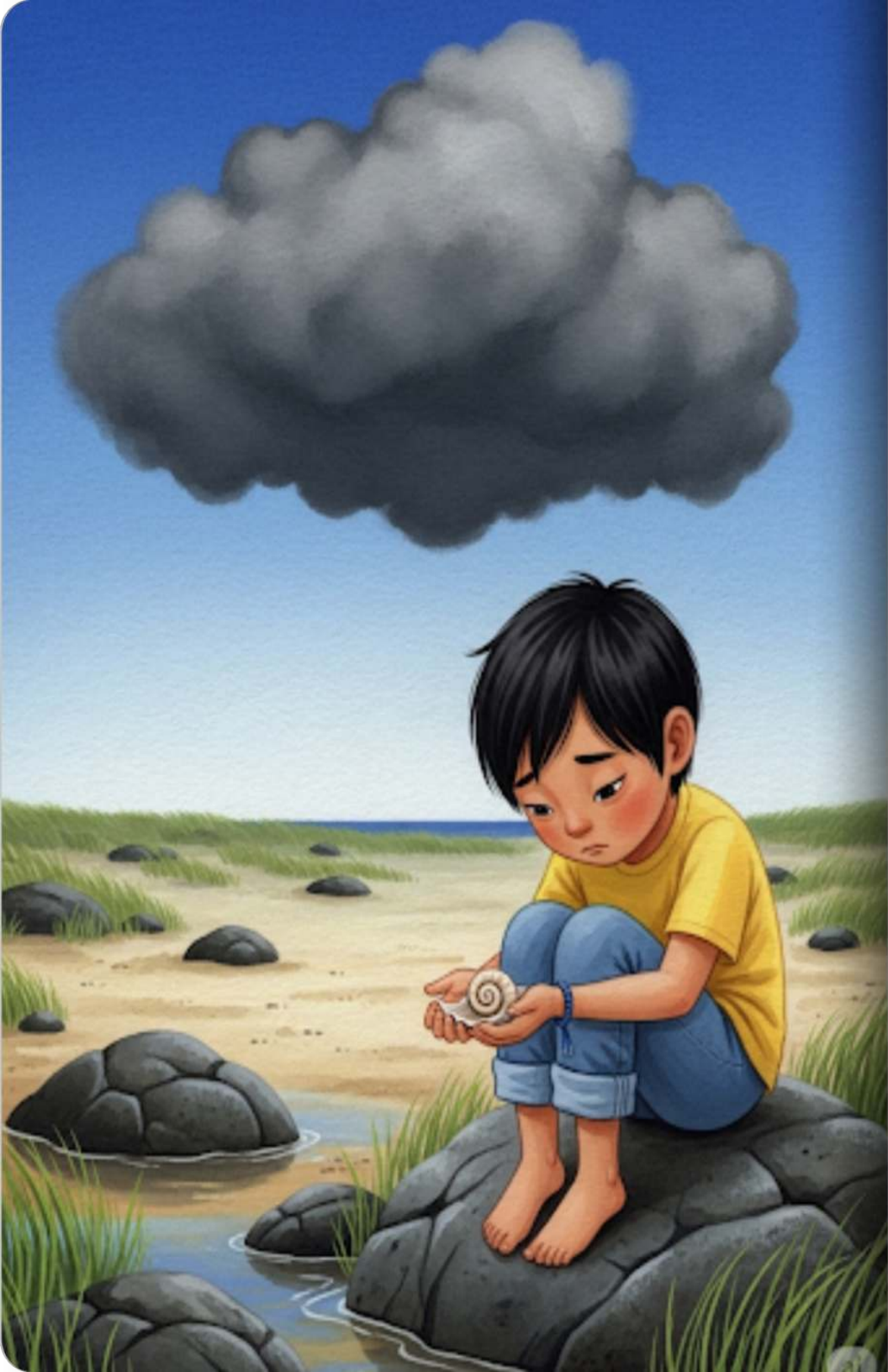


The Jar of Ocean Jewels - Grief Edition

By Michael Mendez



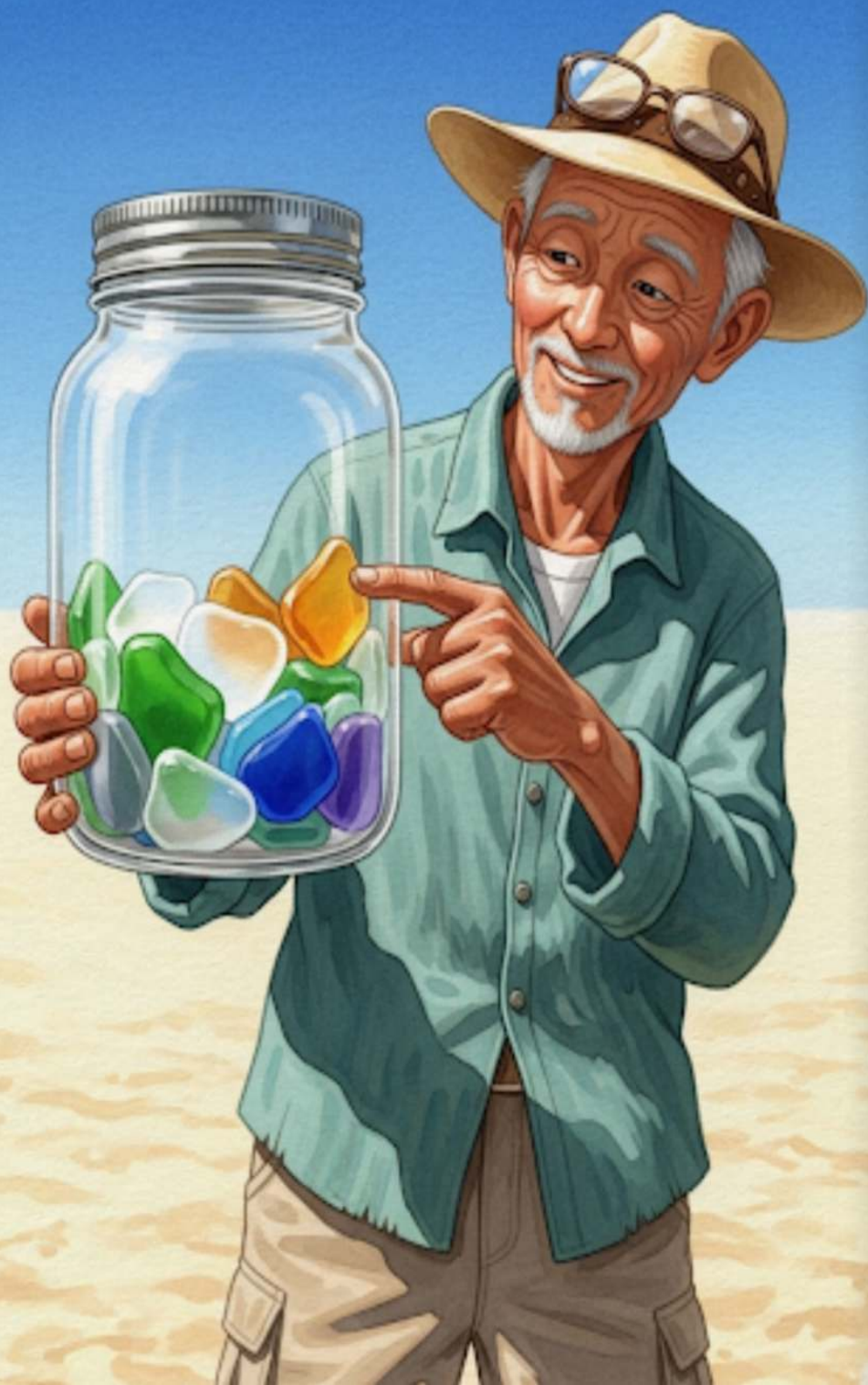
Kai and Soren walked the salt-sprinkled beach where Kai used to hunt for shells with Maren. Since Maren had gone, the beach felt much too quiet. Soren knew Kai's heart felt heavy, like a bucket filled with wet sand that was hard to carry. "Memories are like the tide, Kai," Soren said softly, looking out at the waves. "They come and go, but they always leave something beautiful behind."



The "Heavy Feeling" often followed Kai around. It felt like a big, gray cloud that blocked out the sun, making his chest ache and his eyes sting. Sometimes he just wanted to sit in the sand and let the waves wash everything away. He sat on a cold, gray rock and held a small, empty shell, wishing Maren were there to see it.



Soren sat down on the sand nearby, giving Kai space but staying close. "When the cloud feels too heavy, Kai, we breathe like the sea," Soren whispered. He placed a hand on his chest. "The air comes in like the tide... and goes out like the foam." Kai watched Soren's calm movements. Slowly, Kai tried it too, feeling his chest rise and fall as he remembered Maren's gentle voice.



Soren reached into his bag and pulled out a heavy glass jar. Inside were "Ocean Jewels"—bits of glass in every color, all smooth and soft to the touch. "When Maren and I first found these, they were sharp and broken," Soren explained. "But time and the ocean tumbled them. They didn't stop being glass; they just became something that doesn't hurt to hold anymore."



A small, bright-eyed bird named Teal landed on a piece of driftwood near Kai's feet. Teal looked lost, chirping at the empty sky and hopping from one foot to the other. When a gust of wind blew, Teal huddled close to the wood, looking lonely. Kai saw the "Heavy Feeling" in the bird's sad chirps and reached out, wanting to help.



"It's okay, Teal," Kai whispered. "I miss her too." Kai stayed very still, letting Teal feel safe. The little bird hopped onto Kai's knee and tucked his head under a wing. Kai realized that even though Maren wasn't there to hold him, he could still hold onto the love she gave him. By comforting Teal, Kai felt a little bit of the weight lift from his own heart.

Kai stood up and found a jagged piece of a green bottle that had recently washed ashore. Its edges were still sharp and clear, unlike the jewels in the jar. "This is like the day I had to say goodbye," Kai said quietly. He held it up to the light. It looked painful and sharp, but he knew that one day, the memories would feel as smooth as the jewels in the jar.



"Let's find the world again, Kai," Soren said, standing up and brushing sand from his coat. "Tell me three things Maren loved about today." Kai looked around, thinking hard. "The way the sun sparkles on the water," he said. "The smell of the salty air. And the sound of the seagulls." Soren nodded. "She loved those things, and because you love them too, she is still right here with us."



That night, Kai sat on the porch with Teal resting on his shoulder. The moon made a silver path across the ocean. The waves were still moving, always changing, just like his feelings. He wasn't afraid of the sadness anymore. He had his jar of jewels, his wise friend Soren, and a heart full of memories that would sparkle forever.